

Practically every website gathers data in some form, for analytics, for business or to help improve its end-user experience. Without you knowing it, there's already a significant amount of data out there for interested parties to use, and the process of analysing all this data and following up on its results is still very much being figured out.

Being tracked and targeted, for better or worse

If you've ever tried searching for a product on Flipkart, Myntra, Amazon or any other e-commerce site, then you must've definitely seen that product or item follow you around on a few more websites long after you've exited that e-commerce site. Search for a pair of shoes on Myntra.com and see an ad for that exact shoe follow you around through Google's ad banners, Facebook and some other websites. Post a Facebook update on your new phone purchase and watch how you mysteriously begin to see ads for phone cases and accessories follow you across the interweb.

Social networks are the primary source of this personalised metadata. Browser cookies are the most basic form of such information gathering, however search queries, third-party plug-ins, device-tracking technology (cellular and GPS), and ad networks also study and monitor your browsing pattern to learn more about you.

Just think about it for a second. When you install an app on your smartphone, the amount of access it requires. Or when you create a new social media account, observe the amount of information it asks for, that an unsuspecting individual would be willing to provide. Status updates, images, videos, links, interactions, messages...browse your history just to see how many topics and subjects you've spoken about or commented on during your time online.

This is the exact reason why so many websites offer to connect you to their sites via Facebook or Twitter. Why? Simply because allowing this gives them access to a treasure trove of data that's otherwise inaccessible had you signed up with them exclusively by entering just a measly user name and email address – since all your personal data is heavily invested into social networks like Facebook and Twitter. This works for both, the external



Marvel at the facts presented in the above infographic

website and the social network since the former gets data about its visitors that it otherwise would've missed out on and the latter can acquire more information about your interests, where you're coming from, etc. Both sides profit from this partnership, and therefore you'll find the web littered with these social share buttons and plug-ins.

As for what sort of data is gathered by websites when you're online through

a browser window or an app, here's just the tip of the iceberg: your browsing data takes into account your browser type, time, date, IP address (to know where in the world you are), email address, phone numbers, device information, your location, operating system and other profile information (age, sex, marital status, annual income, etc).

Social networks argue the point that such data is collected to better serve the